

PSY405 - Lesson 24

George Kelly's Cognitive Theory of Personality

1. Overview

- Kelly's theory is **phenomenological**: focuses on the **internal frame of reference** – how a person experiences life from their own perspective.
- **Cognitive**: studies **mental processes** (thinking, predicting, interpreting).
- **Existential**: emphasizes **freedom of choice** and looking toward the **future**.
- **Humanistic**: optimistic, focuses on **creative powers** and problem-solving ability.

Key idea:

- **Behavior and thoughts are guided by personal constructs**, which are mental templates people use to **predict future events**.
- Our actions are shaped by how we **anticipate reality**.

Example: If you see someone frowning, you might predict they are upset (construct: "friendly vs hostile"), and your behavior adjusts accordingly.

2. The Psychology of Personal Constructs

- **Humans are thinking animals.** Kelly emphasized **cognition** as central to personality.
- We are like **scientists**, trying to **understand, predict, and control our experiences**.
- Unlike older theories that saw humans as passive reactors, Kelly said we **actively interpret** events.

Example: You meet a new person and guess if they are trustworthy. Your brain tests hypotheses based on previous experiences.

3. Biographical Sketch

- Born: **1905, Perth, Kansas**, only child.
 - Family: **religious, hardworking, strict**.
 - Education: limited early schooling, later moved to Wichita.
 - Career: professor at Fort Hays Kansas State College, later University of Maryland.
 - Military: **naval aviation psychologist**, training pilots in WWII.
 - Contributions: President of American Psychological Association divisions, promoted **professional psychology**.
 - Focus: rejected Freud, emphasized **real-life practical problems**, not unconscious sexual drives.
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4. Cornerstones of Cognitive Theory

i. Constructive Alternativism

- **Meaning:** Reality can be interpreted in **many ways**. People can choose how to construe events.
- Constructs are **flexible mental templates** that can be revised.
- Once chosen, we often **stick to them**, but we can change them intentionally.

Example: You thought "I fail at exams" → new experience → "I can improve by studying differently."

ii. People as Scientists

- Humans actively **form hypotheses** about life events and **test them**.
- We try to **predict and control our environment**, just like scientists.

Example: You assume "If I smile, people will be friendly." You test it and see if it works.

5. Personal Construct Theory

i. Constructs: Templates for Reality

- **Constructs** = categories we use to **interpret life**.
- We notice **similarities and differences** in events and organize them mentally.
- Freedom to create constructs = **constructive alternativism**.

Examples of constructs:

- Excitable vs calm
 - Good vs bad
 - Intelligent vs stupid
 - Friendly vs hostile
 - These constructs guide behavior, predict outcomes, and shape personality.
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ii. Formal Properties of Constructs

- Each construct has a **range of convenience**: how broadly it applies.
 - *Example*: "Good vs bad" applies to most situations; "virginity vs prostitution" applies very narrowly.
 - Constructs work best **within their intended range**.
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iii. Types of Constructs

- **Preemptive constructs**: rigid, pigeonhole thinking.
 - *Example*: Labeling someone as "Chicano" and ignoring other qualities.
 - Preemptive constructs **limit flexibility**, while more open constructs allow reinterpretation.
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6. Personality in Kelly's Theory

- Kelly did **not define personality** as a fixed entity.
- **Personality = a person's construct system**.
- To understand someone, we need to know:
 1. Which constructs they use

2. How they organize them
3. How they apply them to predict events

Example: If someone sees the world as “people are mostly good,” their actions and expectations differ from someone who sees the world as “people are selfish.”

Key Takeaways from Handout Style

1. Kelly emphasizes **internal perspective, thinking, and prediction**.
2. Humans act like **scientists**, constantly forming and testing mental models.
3. **Constructive alternativism** = freedom to choose and revise mental constructs.
4. **Personality** = system of personal constructs.
5. Constructs vary in **range** and **rigidity**.
6. Therapy can focus on **changing constructs** to improve emotions and behavior.

SHORT QUESTIONS

1. What is George Kelly's Cognitive Theory of Personality?

Answer:

George Kelly's Cognitive Theory of Personality emphasizes that personality is a product of how individuals perceive, interpret, and anticipate events in their lives. According to Kelly, people are like scientists, constantly developing mental models called **personal constructs** to predict and understand their experiences. His theory is phenomenological (focused on personal experience), cognitive (studies mental processes), existential (emphasizes freedom and the future), and humanistic (optimistic about human potential).

Explanation:

Kelly believed that humans are active participants in their world, not passive responders. We use mental templates (**constructs**) to make sense of reality and

guide our behavior. The way we view life influences our thoughts, emotions, and actions.

Example:

If someone frequently thinks “people are friendly,” they are more likely to approach strangers confidently. Another person with the construct “people are selfish” may avoid social interactions.

Tips:

- Remember: **Personality = Construct System.**
 - Focus on **“humans as scientists”** to recall Kelly’s main metaphor.
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2. What is a personal construct?

Answer:

A personal construct is a mental category or template that an individual uses to interpret and predict events in their life. Constructs are bipolar, meaning they have two opposing poles, such as “friendly vs hostile” or “good vs bad.” People freely create and revise constructs to make sense of their experiences.

Explanation:

Constructs are like lenses or filters through which we view the world. They allow us to **see similarities and differences** between events and anticipate outcomes. This process reduces uncertainty and helps us make decisions.

Example:

A student may use the construct “intelligent vs not intelligent” to evaluate classmates or teachers. Someone labeled as “intelligent” is expected to behave in ways consistent with that construct.

Tips:

- Think: **Constructs = mental filters.**
 - Key feature: bipolarity (opposite ends).
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3. What is constructive alternativism?

Answer:

Constructive alternativism is Kelly's principle that all interpretations of reality are **subject to revision or replacement**. Individuals are free to create their own constructs and can modify them if they are not effective in predicting events.

Explanation:

There is no single "true" way to interpret the world. Everyone can **choose and change their constructs**, which gives flexibility in understanding life. This is a central humanistic and existential element of Kelly's theory.

Example:

A person who believes "I always fail exams" can revise this construct after studying differently and performing well: "I can succeed if I prepare properly."

Tips:

- Memory hook: **Constructive = create, Alternativism = options** → freedom to create alternative views.
 - Helps understand therapy approaches like **fixed-role therapy**, which encourages trying new constructs.
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4. Why does Kelly describe people as scientists?

Answer:

Kelly described people as scientists because individuals continuously **form hypotheses about life, test them, and revise them** based on experience. Like scientists, humans aim to **predict, understand, and control** events in their personal world.

Explanation:

This analogy emphasizes **active cognition**. Humans do not simply react to stimuli; they analyze patterns, anticipate outcomes, and adjust behavior to achieve goals.

Example:

If a person believes "If I am polite, people will respond positively," they test this hypothesis by being polite in social interactions and observe the results.

Tips:

- Think of **hypotheses = personal predictions**.

- The goal is **reducing uncertainty** about life events.
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5. What are the types of personal constructs?

Answer:

Kelly identified different types of constructs based on how rigid or flexible they are:

1. **Preemptive constructs:** Rigid, exclusive, pigeonholing categories. Once something is labeled, it cannot belong to another category.
2. **Flexible constructs:** Open to reinterpretation and revision.

Explanation:

Preemptive constructs limit perception and may cause misunderstanding or stereotyping. Flexible constructs allow growth, adaptation, and learning from new experiences.

Example:

- Preemptive: Labeling a professor as "strict" and ignoring their other qualities.
- Flexible: Labeling the same professor as "strict but fair and supportive," adapting this as you observe new behavior.

Tips:

- Rigid constructs → risk psychological conflict.
 - Flexible constructs → enable learning and healthy personality development.
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6. How does Kelly define personality?

Answer:

Kelly defined personality not as a fixed entity but as a person's **construct system**. Personality is the set of personal constructs that a person uses to interpret experiences and anticipate future events.

Explanation:

Knowing someone's personality involves understanding **which constructs they use, how they organize them, and how they apply them**. Personality is inherently

tied to the way individuals **view and make sense of their world**, not a physical or observable trait.

Example:

Someone who sees the world as “people are mostly good” behaves differently from someone who believes “people cannot be trusted.” Their construct systems shape interactions, decisions, and emotional responses.

Tips:

- Remember: **Personality = the set of mental filters (constructs) a person uses.**
 - This is different from Freud, who focused on unconscious drives.
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7. What is the range of convenience of a construct?

Answer:

The range of convenience is the **set of events to which a particular construct applies effectively**. A construct may work in some situations but not others.

Explanation:

Not all constructs are universal. Using a construct beyond its intended range can cause misinterpretation or errors in predicting events.

Example:

- Construct “good vs bad” has a **wide range**, applicable to most social situations.
- Construct “virginity vs prostitution” has a **narrow range**, relevant only in specific contexts.

Tips:

- Wide range → general, broad utility.
 - Narrow range → specialized, context-specific.
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8. How are personal constructs applied in therapy?

Answer:

Personal constructs are applied in therapy to help individuals **recognize, test, and revise constructs** that limit functioning. **Fixed-role therapy** encourages clients to try new roles and constructs to improve emotional well-being.

Explanation:

If a person has rigid, self-limiting constructs (e.g., "I always fail"), therapy can help them **experiment with new interpretations** to reduce anxiety, guilt, or hostility.

Example:

A socially anxious person may be asked to adopt a "confident, friendly" construct temporarily in social situations to experience alternative outcomes.

Tips:

- Think of therapy as **experimenting with new mental filters**.
 - The goal is **flexibility and adaptability**.
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9. How does Kelly explain emotional states like anxiety, guilt, and hostility?

Answer:

Emotions occur when **constructs fail** to predict or explain events effectively:

- **Anxiety**: when future events are unpredictable within one's construct system.
- **Guilt**: when one acts against a core construct.
- **Hostility**: when one attempts to force events to fit a construct that fails.

Explanation:

Emotional states arise from the **mismatch between expectation and reality**. Constructs provide meaning; when they fail, negative emotions emerge.

Example:

- Anxiety: anticipating a friend's reaction but unsure what will happen.
- Guilt: lying against your "honest vs dishonest" construct.
- Hostility: repeatedly trying to prove someone "wrong" according to your construct.

Tips:

- Constructs guide both perception and emotion.
- Emotional problems → rigid, inaccurate, or ineffective constructs.

A. True/False MCQs

1. **Kelly's Cognitive Theory of Personality is phenomenological because it focuses on external stimuli rather than the individual's internal frame of reference.**

- **Answer:** False
- **Explanation:** Phenomenological means it emphasizes the **internal frame of reference**, i.e., how a person experiences life from their perspective, not just external events.

1. **Constructive alternativism suggests that people are free to revise their interpretations of reality.**

- **Answer:** True
- **Explanation:** Constructive alternativism states that all interpretations of reality are **subject to revision or replacement**, allowing flexibility in thought.

1. **Kelly believed that humans are passive responders to environmental stimuli.**

- **Answer:** False
- **Explanation:** Kelly emphasized that humans **actively interpret, predict, and control** their experiences, like scientists.

1. **A personal construct always applies to every event in a person's life.**

- **Answer:** False
- **Explanation:** Constructs have a **range of convenience**, meaning they are only relevant to certain events.

1. **Kelly's theory is considered humanistic because it emphasizes the creative powers and problem-solving potential of individuals.**

- **Answer:** True

- **Explanation:** Humanistic aspect highlights optimism about people's ability to solve problems and grow.
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B. Conceptual MCQs

1. Which of the following best describes a personal construct?

- a) A biological trait determining personality
- b) A mental template used to interpret events
- c) A fixed emotional state
- d) An unconscious desire

- **Answer:** b) A mental template used to interpret events

- **Explanation:** Personal constructs are **bipolar mental categories** like "friendly vs hostile," used to predict and interpret experiences.

1. What does Kelly mean when he calls humans "scientists"?

- a) Humans always follow laboratory experiments
- b) Humans form hypotheses, test them, and revise them to understand life
- c) Humans depend only on external rules
- d) Humans act on instinct without thought

- **Answer:** b) Humans form hypotheses, test them, and revise them to understand life

- **Explanation:** Humans **actively interpret and predict** experiences, similar to how scientists formulate and test hypotheses.

1. Which of the following is an example of a preemptive construct?

- a) "Intelligent vs not intelligent"
- b) "Strict vs lenient"
- c) "Chicano vs non-Chicano"
- d) "Friendly vs unfriendly"

- **Answer:** c) "Chicano vs non-Chicano"

- **Explanation:** Preemptive constructs are **rigid labels** that exclude alternative interpretations, e.g., ethnic stereotyping.

1. **Range of convenience refers to:**

- a) How widely a construct applies to different events
- b) The number of constructs a person has
- c) The emotional intensity of a construct
- d) The opposite of constructive alternativism

- **Answer:** a) How widely a construct applies to different events

- **Explanation:** Some constructs are broad ("good vs bad"), while others are narrow ("virginity vs prostitution").

1. **Which philosophical approach is NOT associated with Kelly's theory?**

- a) Phenomenology
- b) Existentialism
- c) Humanism
- d) Behaviorism

- **Answer:** d) Behaviorism

- **Explanation:** Behaviorism focuses on **observable behavior and external stimuli**, which Kelly rejected in favor of internal cognition and constructs.
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C. Situational MCQs

1. **A student believes, "If I study hard, I will do well in the exam." They study, but fail. According to Kelly, this situation will likely lead to:**

- a) Confirmation of their construct
- b) Revision of their construct
- c) Ignoring the construct entirely
- d) Adoption of a preemptive construct

- **Answer:** b) Revision of their construct

- **Explanation:** Constructs can be revised when they **fail to predict outcomes**, in line with **constructive alternativism**.

1. **A person labels a colleague as "lazy" and ignores their other qualities. This is an example of:**

- a) Flexible construct
- b) Preemptive construct
- c) Constructive alternativism
- d) Range of convenience

- **Answer:** b) Preemptive construct

- **Explanation:** Preemptive constructs **rigidly categorize people**, limiting flexibility in interpretation.

1. **During therapy, a client is asked to act "confident" even though they feel anxious. This is an example of:**

- a) Range of convenience
- b) Fixed-role therapy
- c) Preemptive construct
- d) Behavioral conditioning

- **Answer:** b) Fixed-role therapy

- **Explanation:** Fixed-role therapy encourages **trying new constructs** to improve functioning and reduce emotional distress.

1. **If a person interprets an argument as a threat to their reputation instead of a minor disagreement, which cognitive process is at play?**

- a) Range of convenience
- b) Emotional determinism
- c) Personal construct application
- d) Constructive alternativism

- **Answer:** c) Personal construct application

- **Explanation:** The person is applying a **construct** (threat vs minor issue) to make sense of the event.
1. **A teenager believes "All teachers are strict." Later, they meet a friendly teacher and adjust their belief. This demonstrates:**
 - a) Preemptive construct
 - b) Constructive alternativism
 - c) Fixed-role therapy
 - d) Rigid personality
- **Answer:** b) Constructive alternativism
 - **Explanation:** The teenager **revises their mental model** to accommodate new evidence, showing the flexibility of constructs.

CHEAT SHEET

1. Overview

Aspect	Explanation	Example / Tip
Phenomenological	Focuses on internal frame of reference , how a person experiences life	Two students fail: "I can improve" vs "I'm stupid"
Cognitive	Studies mental processes : thinking, predicting, interpreting	Predicting friend's behavior
Existential	Emphasizes freedom of choice and future possibilities	Choosing career path based on interests
Humanistic	Optimistic about creative powers & problem-solving	Trying new strategies to solve conflicts

Memory Hook: "P-C-E-H = Perspective, Cognition, Existential, Humanistic"

2. Core Concepts

A. Personal Constructs

- **Definition:** Mental categories used to **interpret and predict events**.
- **Bipolar:** Each has **two poles** (friendly vs hostile, good vs bad).
- **Freedom:** We can create and revise constructs (**constructive alternativism**).
- **Example:** "Intelligent vs stupid" applied to classmates.

B. Constructive Alternativism

- **Definition:** All interpretations of reality are **subject to change**; nothing is fixed.
- **Tip:** Freedom to revise mental models = flexibility.
- **Mnemonic:** "CA = Change Allowed"

C. People as Scientists

- **Definition:** Humans form **hypotheses**, test them, and revise based on experience.
- **Example:** Expecting politeness to get friendly responses → test → revise if outcome differs.

D. Range of Convenience

- **Definition:** The **situations where a construct applies**.
- **Wide range:** "Good vs bad" → almost all situations
- **Narrow range:** "Virginity vs prostitution" → very specific context

E. Types of Constructs

Type	Definition	Example
Preemptive	Rigid, pigeonhole thinking, exclusive	Labeling a professor "strict" and ignoring other traits
Flexible	Open to reinterpretation	Professor "strict but fair and supportive"

3. Personality According to Kelly

- **Definition:** Personality = **construct system**

- **Key Idea:** To know personality → know **which constructs a person uses, how they are organized, and how applied**
- **Example:** "People are mostly good" vs "People are selfish" → different expectations & actions

Memory Hook: Personality = Your Construct System (PCS)

4. Emotions and Constructs

Emotion	Cause (in construct terms)	Example
Anxiety	When events are unpredictable in construct system	Unsure how friend will react
Guilt	Acting against a core construct	Lying against "honest vs dishonest"
Hostility	Trying to force reality to fit construct	Proving someone wrong repeatedly

5. Therapy Applications

- **Fixed-role therapy:** Clients try **new roles or constructs** to improve behavior and emotional health.
- **Goal:** Flexibility → reduced anxiety, guilt, hostility
- **Example:** Socially anxious person acts "confident" in social situations

Tips: Think of therapy as "**experimenting with new mental filters**".

6. C-P-C Cycle (Basic Idea)

- **C-P-C = Circumspection – Preemption – Control**
 - **Definition:** The cognitive process of **choosing and applying constructs**:
 1. **Circumspection:** Consider alternative constructs
 2. **Preemption:** Select one construct for a situation
 3. **Control:** Apply it to interpret/predict events
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7. Quick Keywords & Definitions

Keyword	Definition
Personal Construct	Mental template to predict/interpret life events
Constructive Alternativism	Freedom to choose/modify constructs
Scientist Analogy	Humans test hypotheses about life like scientists
Range of Convenience	Events where construct applies
Preemptive Construct	Rigid, exclusive mental category
Flexible Construct	Open to reinterpretation
Fixed-Role Therapy	Trying new constructs to improve functioning

8. Memory Mnemonics / Hooks

- **P-C-E-H:** Phenomenological, Cognitive, Existential, Humanistic
- **CA = Change Allowed:** Constructive Alternativism → revise constructs
- **PCS = Personality = Construct System**
- **C-P-C:** Circumspection → Preemption → Control

9. Small Examples Table

Concept	Example
Personal Construct	Friendly vs hostile
Constructive Alternativism	Revising "I always fail" → "I can improve with preparation"
Preemptive Construct	Labeling someone as "lazy" and ignoring other traits
Flexible Construct	"Strict but fair" professor label
Scientist Analogy	Testing if politeness gets positive social response

10. Tips & Tricks for Quick Revision

1. **Think in opposites:** Almost all constructs are **bipolar**.
2. **Link emotions to constructs:** Anxiety, guilt, hostility = construct mismatch.

3. **Situational MCQs:** Apply concepts → "What would this person do/predict?"
4. **Therapy questions:** Remember **fixed-role therapy = experimenting with new constructs.**
5. **Memory trick for main ideas:** P-C-E-H → PCS → CA → C-P-C